INGLESE · CLASSE QUINTA

The Victorian Age: history, society and the novel

The early years of Victoria's reign, city life, the Victorian frame of mind, the age of fiction, Charles Dickens and *Oliver Twist*

How to read these notes. Blue boxes contain the **definitions** you need to know, green boxes the **examples**, yellow boxes the points where it is **easy to make mistakes**. Italian translations of difficult words are in grey italics. Parts taken from the textbook (and not in your class notes) are flagged under the heading. A yellow band marks where the topics **not yet covered in class** begin. At the end you will find a summary, self-check questions with answers, and a list of corrections to your notes.

1. The early years of Queen Victoria's reign (1837–1861)

The **Victorian Age** takes its name from Queen Victoria, who reigned from **1837 to 1901**. It is usually divided into two parts: the **early years** of the reign (1837–1861, until the death of Prince Albert) and the **late years**. These notes cover the early years.

1.1 Queen Victoria

Birth, parents and length of reign come from the textbook (p. 234).

Victoria was **born in London in 1819**, the daughter of the Duke of Kent and of a strict German princess. In **1837**, at only **18 years old**, she succeeded her uncle **William IV** to the throne *(salì al trono)*, and she ruled for **64 years**.

In **1840** she married her cousin **Albert of Saxe-Coburg-Gotha**. They had **nine children**, and this devoted couple was seen as a **model of respectability and family life**. This image matters: respectability became one of the key values of the whole age (see section 3). In **1861** Albert died suddenly, at the age of 42.

1.2 The main features of the early years

The first years of Victoria's reign were a period of:

Feature	What it means
Social reforms	laws improving working and living conditions (e.g. the Ten Hours Act)
Political reforms	more people asking for, and gradually getting, the right to vote
Material progress	industry, trade, railways and new technology
Imperial expansion	new markets and territories abroad, especially India

Part of the merit for these achievements belonged to the queen herself. Unlike other European monarchs, she **reigned constitutionally** *(in modo costituzionale)*: she **never overruled Parliament** and

acted as a **mediator above party politics**. For this reason Britain **avoided the revolutions** which spread all over Europe in **1848**.

> **DEFINITION**
> To **reign constitutionally** means that the monarch respects the limits set by the constitution and the decisions of Parliament, instead of governing alone.

1.3 Political and social reforms

The Great Reform Act and the end of Chartism come from the textbook (p. 234).

In these years there was a **strong working-class movement** calling for social reform. The **Great Reform Act of 1832** had already extended the vote to almost all men of the **middle classes**, but it had done very little for the **working class**.

This is why **Chartism** was born. In **1838** the Chartists drew up *(redigere)* the **People's Charter**, which asked for social reforms and for the **extension of the right to vote to all male adults**. The movement slowly died, but many of its objectives, like the **secret ballot**, were later achieved through Parliament.

> **DEFINITION**
> **Secret ballot** *(voto segreto)*: a vote where the confidentiality of each voter's choice is guaranteed.

Other social reforms regulated factory life. The **Ten Hours Act of 1847** limited working hours to **ten a day for all labourers**.

On a political level, two main parties **alternated in government**:

- the **Liberals**, mainly formed from the former **Whigs**;
- the **Conservatives**, who evolved from the old **Tories**.

The Liberals promoted **free trade** *(libero scambio)*, and in **1846** they brought about *(portare a)* the **repeal** *(abrogazione)* of the **Corn Laws**. These laws had kept the price of corn artificially high to protect the **landowners' interests**.

The repeal also tried to bring relief to **Ireland**, where a disease of the potato, the main food of the population, had caused the **Potato Famine**, with terrible poverty and numerous deaths. The **Famine Memorial** in Dublin remembers these victims.

> **WATCH OUT**
> **Repeal** means *revoking* a law, not passing it. The Liberals did not create the Corn Laws: they **abolished** them. Free trade means fewer barriers to trade, so cheaper corn.

1.4 Material progress

The details on the Crystal Palace and the «Railway mania» box come from the textbook (p. 235).

Social unrest did not stop the growing power of the **middle classes** or the expansion of **industry and trade**, which were helped by great **scientific and technological developments**.

This progress was celebrated in the **Great Exhibition of 1851**, where goods from all over the world were shown. It was held in the **Crystal Palace** in **Hyde Park** (London), a huge structure designed by **Sir Joseph Paxton** and entirely prefabricated in **iron and glass**. It was the first exhibition of its kind, attracted huge crowds and was strongly supported by **Prince Albert**. Its profits were used to found the **Science Museum**, the **Natural History Museum** and the **Victoria and Albert Museum**.

EXAMPLE · RAILWAY MANIA

The first steam locomotives helped make Britain the most powerful nation in the world. In **1825** the Stockton and Darlington line was the first where a steam locomotive pulled wagons; in **1830** the Liverpool and Manchester Railway opened. Railways were planned to carry goods, but they soon carried mainly **passengers**. The rush to build them was called **«railway mania»**: in **1845** alone Parliament passed 240 acts, which led to 4,600 miles of track.

1.5 Imperial expansion

Dates, consequences of the wars and the details on India come from the textbook (p. 235).

The expansion of **railway building** and **manufacturing production** created more goods than Britain could sell at home, so it needed **new markets abroad**. Foreign trade was so important that Britain was ready to **fight wars to protect its trading routes** *(rotte commerciali)*:

- two **Opium Wars** against **China** (**1839–1842** and **1856–1860**), which gave Britain access to five Chinese ports and control of **Hong Kong**;
- the **Crimean War** (**1853–1856**), in which Britain, together with France, supported the **Ottoman Empire** to **contain Russia**.

The most important and profitable area for Britain was **India**, a key market for British goods. It was ruled by the **East India Company**, which acted as a sovereign power on behalf of the Crown. In **1857** Indian soldiers led the **Indian Mutiny** *(ammutinamento)*, an anti-British rebellion against their British commanders, backed by local rulers and thousands of people. Britain had to put it down *(reprimere)* by force. As a consequence, the East India Company was **dissolved** and India was **administered directly by the British government**. In November **1858** Queen Victoria promised Indians rights similar to those of other British subjects.

DEFINITION

A **mutiny** is a rebellion against the authorities, especially by soldiers against their commanders.

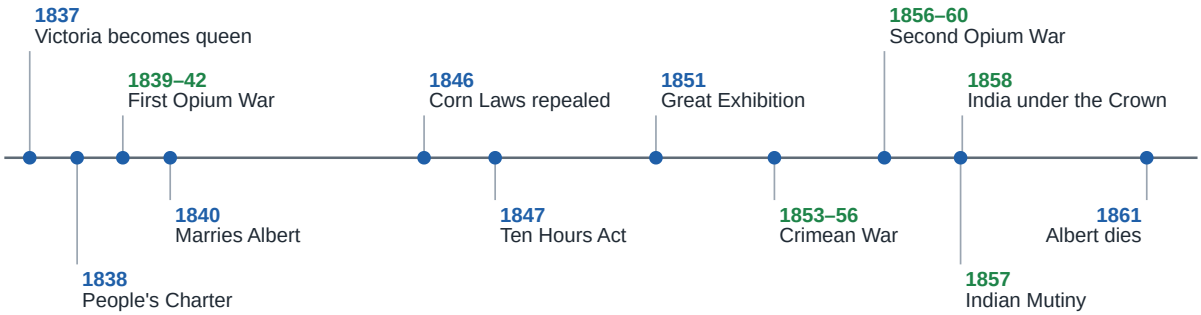


Figure 1 – The early years of Victoria's reign: home events in blue, wars and empire in green.

FINE DEGLI ARGOMENTI TRATTATI IN CLASSE

Da qui in giù, **alla data dell'08/11/2026**, il resto della dispensa **non è ancora stato trattato in classe**.

2. City life in Victorian Britain

2.1 A nation of town dwellers

Thanks to its extraordinary **industrial development**, by the middle of the 19th century Britain had become a nation of **town dwellers** *(abitanti di città)*: the census of 1851 recorded **half of the population** living in towns.

However, the urban environment was **overcrowded**, and finding solutions to this problem was at the heart of Victorian **political and social reforms**.

2.2 Slums, disease and crime

Most of the city poor lived in unhealthy **slum districts** *(bassifondi)* overrun by **disease and crime**. Working conditions were terrible and the air was polluted, mainly by **industrial smoke**. These polluted environments had a disastrous effect especially on **children's health**, and the mortality rate was high.

The towns were also hit by **epidemics** of **cholera** and **typhoid** *(colera e tifo)*, carried by **polluted water**. In **1851** two **Housing Acts** were passed to clean up the towns, but the changes and their effects were **very slow**.

The result was a city of contrasts: for every **grand public building**, just around the corner there were rows of **terraced houses** *(case a schiera)* and slums. Terraced houses were built in great numbers for the working class, to meet the needs of highly populated areas.

2.3 Poverty and the workhouses

Poverty was widespread, and the only relief available was the **workhouse**. The workhouse system was set up under the **Poor Law Amendment Act of 1834** to help the vulnerable. People were given a place to stay **in return for their work**:

- the homeless and the unemployed;
- orphaned and abandoned children;
- disabled and elderly people;
- unmarried women (unmarried mothers).

In reality, workhouses became famous for their **appalling conditions** *(spaventose)*: forced child labour, malnutrition, beatings and neglect. Everyone had to work hard, **families were separated**, and food and clothing were scarce and poor. Children could even be sold to work in factories or mines.

Why were they so harsh? Because the Victorians saw **poverty as a consequence of laziness**: terrible conditions were supposed to push the poor to improve themselves. Yet the workhouses gave no real means for social or economic progress.

DEFINITION

A **workhouse** was a public institution where the poor received food and a place to sleep in exchange for hard work, under very strict rules.

2.4 How life in the cities improved

The professional organisations and the «Link to citizenship» box come from the textbook (p. 236).

The early Victorian years were also a period of real improvement:

- **Medicine** changed radically: modern **hospitals** were built and professional organisations were founded to regulate medical education and research.
- **Common services** were gradually introduced: running water, gas, **street lighting** and paved roads.
- **Places of entertainment** were built: public houses (today's **pubs**), music halls, parks and stadiums.
- Other solid Victorian buildings, still visible in British cities today: prisons, police stations, boarding schools and town halls.

WATCH OUT

Pub is short for **public house**. A **boarding school** *(collegio)* gives pupils «board and lodging» (UK), in American English «room and board»: a room to sleep in and meals.

EXAMPLE · LINK TO CITIZENSHIP

Victorian cholera and typhoid came from dirty water. Today, the UN **Sustainable Development Goal 6** («Clean water and sanitation») reminds us that billions of people still lack safe drinking water and sanitation, which are essential to prevent and contain diseases.

3. The Victorian frame of mind

3.1 An age of contradictions: the Victorian compromise

The expression «Victorian compromise» and the idea of the world «as they wanted it to be» come from the textbook (p. 237).

The Victorian Age was a **complex and contradictory** era. On one hand it was an age of progress; on the other it was marked by poverty and injustice.

On one hand…	…on the other hand
progress (Industrial Revolution)	poverty
wealth of the upper and middle classes	injustice
stability and social reforms	social unrest

The Victorians were great **moralisers**. They faced so many problems that they felt obliged to support certain values which seemed to offer a way out: **duty**, **hard work**, **respectability** and **charity**. These

values described the world **as they wanted it to be, not as it really was**: this is the **Victorian compromise**.

The values were refined mainly by the **upper and middle classes**, who had political and economic power, but they were applied to **all strata of society**. In an age that believed in progress, it seemed natural that material progress came from **hard work**: so the Victorians insisted on a **sense of duty** rather than on **personal inclination**.

> **DEFINITION**
> The **Victorian compromise** is the gap between the moral image the Victorians gave of their society and the reality of poverty and injustice behind it.

3.2 Respectability and philanthropy

Respectability was what distinguished the **middle class** from the lower classes. It was a mixture of:

- morality and **hypocrisy**; severity; conformity to social standards;
- good manners;
- a comfortable house with servants and a carriage *(carrozza)*;
- regular attendance at church and **charitable activities**.

Philanthropy was widespread: thousands of Victorians, mainly **women**, helped «stray children, fallen women and drunken men».

3.3 Victorian family life

The marginalisation of unmarried mothers comes from the textbook (p. 237).

Middle-class ideals dominated family life. The family was **patriarchal**: the **husband** represented **authority**, while the **wife** was in charge of the **education of the children** and the **management of the house**.

Society was deeply concerned about **female chastity** *(castità)*: unmarried mothers were marginalised as **«fallen women»**. **Sexuality** was repressed both in public and in private, and moralising **prudery**, in its most extreme forms:

- denounced nudity in art;
- veiled the genitals of sculptures;
- rejected words with a sexual connotation from everyday vocabulary.

The Italian translations below are the ones asked in exercise 2 of the textbook (p. 237).

English	Italian
respectability	rispettabilità
charity	carità, beneficenza
sense of duty	senso del dovere
conformity	conformismo
philanthropy	filantropia
prudery	pudore eccessivo, bigottismo

4. The age of fiction

4.1 Why the novel became so popular

During the Victorian Age the **novel** was the most popular form of literature and the main source of **entertainment**, because novels were **read aloud within the family**.

For the first time there was a **communion of interests** between writers and readers. One reason was the huge growth of the **middle classes** (mainly women), who:

- borrowed books from **circulating libraries**, paying an annual fee or a fee per book;
- read **periodicals**, where many novels were first published **in instalments** *(a puntate)*.

4.2 The novelist's aim

«Not radical» comes from the textbook (p. 243).

Novelists felt they had a **moral and social responsibility**. They reflected the social changes of their time: the **Industrial Revolution**, the **struggle for democracy** and the **growth of towns**. They described society as they saw it and denounced its evils. Their criticism, however, was **not radical**: it simply aimed at making readers **aware of social injustices**.

4.3 Features of the Victorian novel

The «barrier between right and wrong» comes from the textbook (p. 243).

Element	Feature
Narrator	**omniscient**; comments on the plot and draws a rigid line between «right» and «wrong», light and darkness
Ending	the final chapter explains and justifies all events and shows **retribution** (reward) and **punishment**
Plot	long, complicated, often with **subplots**
Setting	**the city**, symbol of industrial civilisation and of anonymous lives and lost identities
Characters	**realistic**, because readers loved identifying with them

> **DEFINITION**
> An **omniscient narrator** knows everything about the story and the characters, including their thoughts, and can comment on events and judge them.

4.4 Types of novel

- **Social and humanitarian novels** belong to the first part of the Victorian Age. Their main representative is **Charles Dickens**.
- **Romantic and Gothic novels** continue the Romantic and Gothic traditions and focus on intense **subjective experiences** rather than on society. The key names are the Brontë sisters: **Charlotte Brontë** (*Jane Eyre*) and **Emily Brontë** (*Wuthering Heights*).

4.5 Women writers

Many novels were written by **women**, which is surprising given their subjected role. The explanation is that **most novel-buyers and readers were women**, who spent more time at home. However, it was not easy for women to publish, because creative writing was considered a **masculine** activity: so some of them hid behind a **male pseudonym**.

5. Charles Dickens (1812–1870)

5.1 His life

Charles Dickens was born in **Portsmouth**, on the south coast of England, in **1812**. He had an **unhappy childhood**: his father was **imprisoned for debt**, and at **12** Charles was sent to work in a **blacking factory** *(fabbrica di lucido da scarpe)*. When his father was released, he went to a school in London.

His work experiences shaped his writing:

- at **15** he worked as an **office boy** *(fattorino)* in a lawyer's office;
- by **1832** he was a **shorthand reporter** *(stenografo, cronista)* of **parliamentary debates** in the House of Commons, and then a **reporter** for a newspaper;
- using the pseudonym **«Boz»** he published *Sketches by Boz*, articles and tales about London people and scenes;
- with *The Pickwick Papers*, published in instalments, he showed his **humorous and satirical** qualities;
- after this success he became a **full-time novelist**.

In **1842** he visited **Canada and the USA** to speak in favour of **international copyright** and the **abolition of slavery**. He died in **1870** and was buried in **Westminster Abbey**.

5.2 His works

Year	Work	Notes
1833	first story	
1836	*Sketches by Boz*; *The Pickwick Papers*	London scenes; humour and satire
1837–39	*Oliver Twist*	autobiographical elements; in instalments
1839	*Nicholas Nickleby*	
1842	*American Notes*	American references, after the 1842 journey
1844	*Martin Chuzzlewit*	
1843	*A Christmas Carol*	
1850	*David Copperfield*	autobiographical
1853	*Bleak House*	social issues
1854	*Hard Times*	social issues
1857	*Little Dorrit*	autobiographical
1861	*Great Expectations*	social issues

His works fall into two groups. The **autobiographical novels** (*Oliver Twist*, *David Copperfield*, *Little Dorrit*) use his photographic memory of his childhood: their young heroes are symbols of an **exploited childhood**, facing the bitter reality of slums and factories. Other novels (*Bleak House*, *Hard Times*, *Great Expectations*) cover **social issues** such as the condition of the poor and the working class.

5.3 Dickens and London

This part comes from the textbook (p. 244).

London is the setting of most of his novels, and he knew it intimately. Over time he developed a **more and more critical attitude** towards his society, though he never became a revolutionary. In his mature works he mixed terrible descriptions of London's misery and crime with **amusing sketches** of the city, drawing public attention to abuses and wrongs.

5.4 Characters

The shift from the upper-middle-class world to the lower orders comes from the textbook (p. 245).

Dickens moved the novel's **social frontiers**: the upper-middle-class world of 18th-century novels was replaced by the world of the **lower orders**. He created **characters and caricatures** who live immortally in English imagination. To arouse *(stimolare)* readers' interest he **exaggerated** his characters' habits and language.

> **EXAMPLE · CARICATURE**
> **Shopkeepers** *(negozianti)* and **tradesmen** *(commercianti)* of the London middle and lower classes: Dickens ridiculed their **vanity and ambition** freely, but without sarcasm.

Dickens was always **on the side of the poor**, the **outcast** *(emarginati)* and the working class. **Children** are often the most important characters: they are examples of **goodness and wisdom** in contrast with **worthless** *(inutili, indegni)* adults, and Dickens offers them as **models** of how people ought to behave.

5.5 Didactic aim

Dickens denounced social problems such as the appalling conditions of the poor in **workhouses**, in **slums**, and **child labour**. His purpose was **not** to make the poor rebel or to encourage discontent, but to make the **ruling classes aware** of these problems, without offending his middle-class readers. Through his novels, the wealthier classes learned about their poorer neighbours, of whom they **knew nothing** before.

> **WATCH OUT**
> Dickens wrote to inform the **rich**, not to stir up the **poor**. His criticism is reformist, not revolutionary: this is the same «non radical» criticism of the Victorian novel (section 4.2).

5.6 Style

Repetitions and juxtapositions come from the textbook (p. 245).

- **graphic and powerful descriptions** of life and characters;
- **detailed characterisation**;
- a careful choice of **many adjectives**;
- **repetitions** of words and structures and **juxtapositions** *(accostamenti)* of images and ideas;
- **hyperboles** *(iperboli)* and **irony**.

6. *Oliver Twist* (1838)

6.1 Plot

The half-brother and the arrest of the gang leaders come from the textbook (p. 246).

Oliver Twist is an orphan: his father is unknown and his mother died giving birth to him. He grows up in a **workhouse** in inhuman conditions, with tiny rations of **gruel** *(farinata)*, a mixture of oat *(avena)* or barley *(orzo)* and water.

Chosen by the other boys, he asks the **master** of the workhouse for more food. The beadle, **Mr Bumble**, reports this to the board, and Oliver is punished: the parish offers **five pounds** to anyone who will take him, and he becomes the apprentice of an **undertaker** *(becchino, impresario di pompe funebri)*.

The cruelty of his new master pushes him to run away to **London**. There he falls into a gang of **pickpockets** *(borseggiatori)* led by the **Artful Dodger** and trained by the old **Fagin**, who want to make a thief out of him. On his first mission he is arrested, but the victim of the theft, **Mr Brownlow**, takes him into his home.

The gang **kidnaps** him again and forces him to take part in a **burglary** *(furto con scasso)* in the house of **Mrs Maylie**, where he is **shot and wounded**. Mrs Maylie takes care of him and gives him the kindness he had never received. In the end he is adopted by Mr Brownlow.

Thanks to **Nancy**, a member of the gang with a kind heart, it is discovered that Oliver has **noble origins**. Nancy is murdered; Fagin is caught and sentenced to hanging; the gang leaders and Oliver's **half-brother** *(fratellastro)*, who had paid the thieves to ruin Oliver and keep their father's property for himself, are arrested. Oliver gets his **inheritance** and can finally live a peaceful life in the countryside.

6.2 London life

The details in brackets come from the textbook (p. 246).

London, the most important setting, is shown on **three social levels**:

World	How it is shown
The parish world of the workhouse	run by people of the **lower middle class**, calculating and insensitive to the feelings of the poor
The criminal world	**poverty drives people to crime**; pickpockets and murderers live in squalid slums (which «blacken the soul»), in fear, destined to a miserable death
The world of the middle class	respectable people with good manners and moral values (who believe in **human dignity**)

6.3 Themes

Domestic servants and chimney sweepers come from the textbook (p. 246).

- the **cruelty of institutions**, like the workhouse;
- the **cruelty of people** towards the vulnerable, especially children;
- children who are **innocent** or **corrupted by adults**;
- **childhood**;
- **poverty** and its effects on people's lives;
- **forced work**: poor children who escaped early death had to work in factories and mines, or as domestic servants and chimney sweepers *(spazzacamini)*;
- **crime**, the way out chosen by others.

6.4 Text T29: «Oliver wants some more» (Chapter 2)

This whole part comes from the textbook (p. 247–248).

This extract shows Dickens's awareness of the social problems of his time.

What happens. The boys eat in a large stone hall. The master serves the gruel from a copper *(paiolo di rame)*: one porringer *(scodella)* each and no more, except on special occasions, when they get two ounces and a quarter of bread. The boys polish their bowls with their spoons and suck their fingers, still starving. After three months, one tall boy says that if he does not get more gruel, he may eat the weak boy who sleeps next to him. They draw lots *(tirano a sorte)*, and the task falls to Oliver. After supper, pushed by the others with winks and nudges, he walks up to the master and says: «Please, sir, I want some more.»

The fat, healthy master turns pale with astonishment, hits Oliver with the ladle and calls the beadle. Mr Bumble rushes into the meeting of the board and announces the scandal. A gentleman in a white

waistcoat declares that the boy «will be hung». Oliver is locked up, and the next morning a notice offers **five pounds** to anyone who will take him as an apprentice.

Words in context	
devour – eat hungrily	**suck** – draw into the mouth
appetite – a desire for food	**starvation** – suffering due to lack of food
voracious – eating large quantities	**beadle** – sorvegliante
board – consiglio (direttivo)	**reckless** – imprudente

Narrator and narrative modes. The narrator is **third-person and omniscient**. The passage alternates **detailed description** (the hall, the bowls, the boys' hunger) and **narration**, which moves the story quickly, with short **dialogues** that make the key moment dramatic and lively. Dickens uses **irony**: he calls the miserable gruel a «festive composition» and lets the gentleman's absurd «prophecy» go unquestioned.

Contrasting images. The scene is built on opposites, typical of Dickens's style:

The boys	The adults in charge
poverty, starvation	richness, fatness (the «fat, healthy» master)
submission, fear	power, lack of humanity

A simple request for food is treated as a crime: this shows the **cruelty of institutions** (section 6.3) and the **didactic aim** of Dickens, who wants readers to feel outrage at the workhouse system.

> EXAMPLE · OLIVER AND DICKENS
>
> Both are **poor children** who suffer hardship very young and are **sent to work**: Oliver as an undertaker's apprentice, Dickens in a blacking factory at 12. Both lack a stable family: Oliver is an orphan, Dickens's father was in prison for debt.

> EXAMPLE · LINK TO TODAY
>
> Children living and working in poor conditions still exist today, in many developing countries: Oliver's story is not only history.

7. Review

7.1 Summary

COVERED IN CLASS

1. Victoria reigned from 1837 to 1901; the early years (1837–1861) end with Albert's death.
2. She reigned constitutionally, so Britain avoided the 1848 revolutions.
3. The People's Charter (1838) asked for the vote for all male adults; Chartism died, but some aims, like the secret ballot, were reached later.

4. Liberals (ex Whigs) and Conservatives (ex Tories) alternated; the Liberals repealed the Corn Laws in 1846, also to help famine-stricken Ireland.
5. Industry and trade grew, celebrated by the Great Exhibition of 1851 in the Crystal Palace.
6. The need for markets led to the Opium Wars, the Crimean War and direct British rule in India after the 1857 Mutiny.

NOT YET COVERED IN CLASS

7. Cities were overcrowded; slums spread disease (cholera, typhoid) and crime.
8. Workhouses (Poor Law, 1834) were meant to help the poor but were cruel, because poverty was seen as laziness.
9. The Victorian compromise: values (duty, hard work, respectability, charity) hid poverty and injustice.
10. The novel was the main entertainment; it had an omniscient narrator, long plots, city settings and realistic characters.
11. Dickens wrote to make the ruling classes aware of social problems, using caricature, children as models and powerful descriptions.
12. *Oliver Twist* attacks the cruelty of institutions and shows London on three social levels.

7.2 Self-check questions

Try to answer without looking at your notes, then check on the next page.

COVERED IN CLASS

1. What does «reigning constitutionally» mean, and why was it important for Britain in 1848?
2. Why was Chartism born, and what happened to its demands?
3. Why were the Corn Laws repealed, and what was the link with Ireland?
4. Why did Britain need markets abroad, and what were the consequences in China and in India?

NOT YET COVERED IN CLASS

5. Why were the slums so dangerous for children?
6. What were workhouses supposed to do, and why were they so harsh in practice?
7. What is meant by the «Victorian compromise»?
8. How did respectability distinguish the middle class from the lower classes?
9. Why did the novel become the most popular form of literature?
10. What was Dickens's didactic aim, and who were his target readers?
11. Which three «worlds» of London appear in *Oliver Twist*?
12. In «Oliver wants some more», how does Dickens contrast the boys and the adults, and why?

7.3 Answers

1. It means respecting Parliament and acting as a mediator above parties instead of governing alone. Because the monarchy did not oppose Parliament, Britain avoided the revolutions that spread across Europe in 1848.
2. The Great Reform Act of 1832 gave the vote to middle-class men but not to workers. The Chartists asked for the vote for all male adults (People's Charter, 1838). The movement died, but some aims, like the secret ballot, were later achieved through Parliament.
3. They kept corn prices artificially high to protect landowners; the Liberals, in favour of free trade, repealed them in 1846. Cheaper corn was also meant to help Ireland, hit by the Potato Famine.
4. Industry and railways produced more goods than Britain could sell at home. This led to the Opium Wars (Hong Kong and five Chinese ports) and, after the 1857 Mutiny, to the end of the East India Company and direct rule of India by the British government.
5. They were overcrowded and polluted, with high mortality; dirty water carried cholera and typhoid, and children worked and lived in terrible conditions.
6. They were supposed to give food and shelter to the poor in return for work. They were harsh because poverty was considered a result of laziness, so bad conditions were meant to push people to improve themselves.
7. The Victorians promoted values (duty, hard work, respectability, charity) that showed the world as they wanted it to be, hiding the poverty, injustice and unrest of reality.
8. Through good manners, moral conformity, a comfortable house with servants and a carriage, church attendance and charity: things the lower classes could not have.
9. Novels were read aloud in families; the growing middle class borrowed them from circulating libraries and read them in instalments in periodicals; and writers dealt with the same issues as their readers.
10. He wanted to make the ruling, wealthier classes aware of the conditions of the poor, without offending his middle-class readers; he did not want the poor to rebel.
11. The parish world of the workhouse, the criminal world of the slums, and the respectable world of the middle class.
12. The boys are hungry, submissive and afraid; the adults are fat, powerful and inhuman. The contrast shows the cruelty of institutions and makes readers feel outrage.

Appendix: what was corrected compared with your notes

Topic	In your notes	Correct version
Oliver Twist – the burglary	Oliver is forced to break into Mr Brownlow's house again	The burglary is in the house of **Mrs Maylie**, not Mr Brownlow's
Oliver Twist – Mrs Maylie	Mr Brownlow's housekeeper	The lady of the burgled house, who nurses Oliver; Mr Brownlow adopts him later
Oliver Twist – the request	Oliver speaks to Mr Bumble about more food	Oliver asks the **master**; Mr Bumble (the beadle) reports it to the board (T29)
Oliver Twist – five pounds	Oliver is «sold for 5 pounds»	The parish **offers** 5 pounds to whoever takes him as an apprentice (T29)
Dickens – didactic aim	to make **working-class** readers aware	to make the **ruling (wealthier) classes** aware, without offending middle-class readers (p. 245)
City life – epidemics	air polluted also by epidemics	epidemics were carried by **polluted water**; air pollution came from industrial smoke
City life – services	street lightning	**street lighting** (lightning = fulmine)